Abstention, selection and the Blue Wall

2016 and 2024 | Executed findings | ECON 438 Project 1

What the data support

• The baseline allocated Democratic share falls from 58.6% to 55.4%. The 3.15 percentage-point decline is not significant at 5% (state-clustered p = 0.077).

• The selection model instead predicts 69.8% and 84.8%. Its cross-year change is also not significant (p = 0.368); the 2016 interval is especially wide.

• Among retained respondents reporting a previous Democratic vote, abstention versus a current Republican vote is 17.7% versus 7.9% in 2016, and 4.1% versus 3.9% in 2024. These are weighted within-sample descriptions, not national voter-flow totals.

• The data are more compatible with abstention exceeding defection among prior Democratic voters in 2016 than in 2024. They do not establish either mechanism as the cause of an election result.

Predicted preference among retained nonvoters

Allocated Democratic preference	2016: estimate (95% CI)	2024: estimate (95% CI)
Baseline, state controls	58.6% (56.0-61.2)	55.4% (51.3-59.6)
Joint binary selection, COVI	69.8% (40.0-99.5)	84.8% (72.1-97.5)

Headline allocation assigns all predicted non-Republican preferences to Democrats. These are scenario shares, not measured Democratic support. Parentheses show 95% intervals in percent.

Selection estimates need a cautious interpretation

• Error correlation: rho = 0.346 in 2016 (p = 0.488) and 0.826 in 2024 (p = 0.001). COVI turnout association: p = 0.001 in 2016; p = 0.128 in 2024. Exclusion validity remains assumed.

• For 2024 nonvoters with a usable pre-election preference, 45.6% stated Republican preference. On that same subset, baseline prediction is 44.1% and selection prediction is 16.0%. The large selection adjustment conflicts with this survey benchmark.

Samples: 32,453 respondents in 2016 and 31,484 in 2024, including 5,539 and 2,185 matched nonvoters. Results target the retained matched, complete-case sample. Only turnout is voter-file validated; prior and current candidate choices are survey reports.

Course-project conclusion: use abstention as a testable electoral scenario. The current results do not establish that Democratic abstention caused both Trump victories.

Battleground thresholds and robustness

Additional participants needed under the all-non-Republicans-to-Democrats allocation

Year / state	Trump lead	Baseline: added voters	Selection: added voters	NV n / Kish n
2016 / MI	10,704	63,667	26,644	205 / 79.6
2016 / WI	22,748	121,493	57,107	118 / 59.1
2016 / PA	44,292	475,572	119,100	292 / 154.1
2024 / MI	80,103	No net D gain	134,397	87 / 13.4
2024 / WI	29,397	132,627	41,983	27 / 6.4
2024 / PA	120,266	731,370	166,645	73 / 7.8

For each added participant, expected Democratic net gain = 1 - 2pR. Minimum participants = floor(Republican lead / net gain) + 1 when net gain is positive. Existing ballots and preferences are held fixed. NV n is the retained nonvoter count; Kish n measures weight concentration, not model precision.

• Michigan 2024 is almost evenly divided in the baseline: allocated Democratic preference is 49.9%. Adding participants with that point-estimated mix does not overturn its Republican lead. The selection model gives a different scenario; all three states cannot be claimed to flip from the baseline estimates.

• Allocation sensitivity is consequential. In Pennsylvania 2016, the baseline needs more than 83.0% of non-Republicans to vote Democratic just to produce a positive Democratic net gain. Allocating only 80% produces no positive net gain there, however many participants are added.

• If all three states flipped, standard state allocations would give Democrats 278 electoral votes in 2016 (before faithless electors) and 270 in 2024, holding every other state fixed. These are arithmetic scenarios, not estimated probabilities of winning.

• The 2024 state nonvoter samples have Kish effective sizes of only about 13 (MI), 6 (WI) and 8 (PA). No state population confidence intervals or aligned state nonvoter population totals are available here. Thresholds are point scenarios, not proof of feasible mobilization.

Robustness: the adjustment changes across specifications

• 2016: alternative selection specifications imply allocated Democratic shares from 60.3% to 65.3% (remove COVI, exclude Utah, region controls; also active-only in 2016). Sample restrictions change the target group.

• 2024: alternative selection specifications imply allocated Democratic shares from 77.7% to 84.8% (remove COVI, exclude Utah, region controls; also active-only in 2016). Sample restrictions change the target group.

What is completed - and what remains

Completed: baseline and selection estimation; clustered uncertainty and cross-year tests; lecture two-step diagnostic; prior-vote transitions and benchmarks; state threshold and allocation grids; specification and matching checks; numerical validation.

A population full-turnout claim still needs aligned state nonvoter totals and a defensible extrapolation beyond matched CES respondents. These data cannot identify Gaza, moderation or Sanders support as causes of abstention.

Sources: CES/COVI releases and provenance in Project/P1/README.md; official returns: FEC Federal Elections 2016 and FEC 2024 Presidential General Election Results; EC allocations: National Archives. Full source URLs, tables, code and execution diagnostics accompany this PDF in the repository.